

Harding Manifesto - Experience and Scars

Introduction

This document serves as a companion to the Harding Systems Design Manifesto. These principles were not written in abstraction; they emerged from sustained exposure to real systems operating under real constraints.

The Reality of Pressure

The "scars" behind these principles were earned in environments where:

- Invisible Failure: Systems failed silently, causing preventable downstream harm.
- Policy Over Physics: Critical capabilities were disabled by billing thresholds or contractual boundaries rather than technical impossibility.
- Politics Over Science: Hero fixes corrected system fixes for the moment but the system rotted from the inside out as a result causing cascading failures.
- Brittle Coupling: Tightly coupled designs turned localized issues into broad operational disruptions.
- Expensive Iteration: Systems were too opaque or burdened by undocumented assumptions to change safely.
- *The Hero Culture*: Short-term "heroic" interventions were rewarded while systemic corrections were deferred.

The Shift in Priority

In these environments, the cost was lost trust, delayed response, damaged infrastructure, and constrained learning. These experiences forced a shift away from optimizing for speed or novelty toward durability, clarity, and autonomy.

The value of a system is not measured by its performance under ideal conditions, but by whether it continues to tell the truth when conditions degrade. This document exists to ensure future systems fail loudly, degrade gracefully, and preserve meaning.